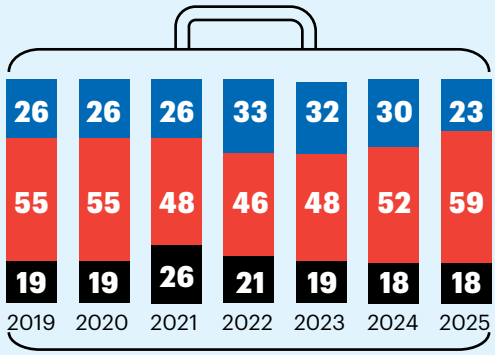
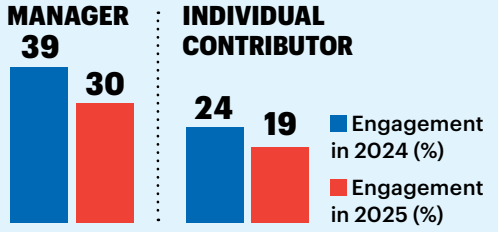
WANING AT WORK

A staggering 59% of Indian employees are doing 'just enough' on the job, the highest since 2019. Another 18% have 'actively disengaged' from work and company



LOOSE SUITS?

While managers are more engaged than individual contributors, their engagement has experienced a greater decline, falling by nine percentage points since 2024*



** Measures employee involvement in and enthusiasm for their work and workplace. Figures are three-year rolling averages for 2023–2025, including a survey of 1,000 respondents, aged 15 or older and working for an employer, collected during January-December 2025*

***Source:** Gallup's State of the Global Workplace 2026 Report*

costs. They are taking the hard call. It manifests as the pattern you've heard of: some jobs vanishing, new ones being created. Oracle, Microsoft, Amazon and Dell have let go of thousands of employees. Layoffs, once uncommon in India, are now a lived reality. 'Hire-and-fire' addresses the company's biological anxieties: getting lean, thrifty and adaptive is a survival tactic. Internally, though, it inevitably rings in a behavioural change. Earlier, companies *wanted* to instil institutional loyalty and retain employees for life. Now they have other, more pressing priorities. That's leading to a huge churn in the labour market, according to industry watchers in tune with talent search.

Anxiety producing not desperation or urgency, but its opposite? Paradoxical? It's a dismal psychological barter—both sides trading a deficit. To the worker, the employer's new attitude signals a lack of constancy, an essential undependability. They feel their office is no longer committed to them, and they are reciprocating. The company-employee relationship is becoming transactional, says Partha Neog, CEO and co-founder of employee engagement platform Vantage Circle. A job was once an integral part of one's identity. Today, there's a new self-affirmative dictum: "You are not your job".



"JUST REPLACING DISENGAGED EMPLOYEES DOES NOT ADDRESS THE CONDITIONS THAT CREATED THE DISENGAGEMENT. YOU RISK RECREATING THE PROBLEM"

PUNEET PRATAP SINGH, *Regional Director, Research & Analytics, Gallup*

At the macro level, think of it like climate change—a volatile, mercurial phase, with chances of extreme events. Rippling through individual offices, it's leaving in its wake a trail of broken patterns. Disenchantment may have once produced conflict or competition. Now, it creates disengagement. Why did Tanya lose her mojo? "All year, I'm entrusted with complex work, but it doesn't translate into a promotion or salary hike," she says. "During appraisal, they flip the story, giving me vague feedback... 'take more initiative, work harder', etc. But that's not how they make me feel through the year." Result: demotivation. Now, she completes cases responsibly, but also carves out personal time—recompense for the salary hike she didn't get. And Sameer? His ex-manager was a "visionary". "Now, I report to a laidback leader who prefers yes-men, plays safe and refrains from cutting-edge projects. Promotions will go to his sycophants. So why waste my effort and intellect? I'll just take my salary," he says.

THE BIRTHMARKS OF AN ERA

A statistical gap stands in the way of assigning proper contours to the phenomenon. Historical data is limited and partial. Gallup's India series, tracking three-year rolling averages since 2012, measures 'engagement'. Organisations measure it internally yet the data is not public. And anyone familiar with Indian offices since the 1970s-80s wouldn't be shocked by data that says '77 per cent of the workforce does the bare minimum work'. So, quiet quitting, as a new form of behaviour, has to be inferred and pieced together circumstantially. Context tells us there are very specific and novel